YEAR 2 · UNIT 18 · DAYS 666-686

The New Covenant Inaugurated: Mark

Mark 1-16

The servant King acts. Urgency, authority, and the suffering Son of Man.

UNIT ANCHOR VERSE

"For even the Son of Man came not to be served but to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for many."

MARK 10:45

Psalms read beside Mark's stories: 107:23-43 (the storm), 89 (the Davidic king), 118:19-29 (the cornerstone), and 69 (the righteous sufferer).

UNIT 18

In this unit

WEEK 96

666	Mark 1:1-45	*Reading*
667	Mark 1:14-15; Luke 17:20-21; 1 Corinthians 15:20-28	*Doctrine*
668	Mark 2:1-3:35	*Reading*
669	Mark 4:1-5:43	*Reading*
670	Mark 6:1-56	*Reading*
671	Psalm 107:23-43	*Psalm*
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673	Psalm 89:1-18	*Psalm*
674	Mark 7:1-8:38	*Reading*
675	Mark 9:1-50	*Reading*
676	Mark 10:1-52	*Reading*
677	Mark 11:1-12:44	*Reading*
678	Mark 13:1-37	*Reading*
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WEEK 98

680	Psalm 118:19-29	*Psalm*
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682	Mark 14:1-52	*Reading*
683	Mark 14:53-15:20	*Reading*
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685	Mark 16:1-20	*Reading*
686	Review and Reflection	*Review and Sabbath*

DAY 666 · WEEK 96

Mark 1:1-45

"Immediately", the Kingdom arrives with authority

Year 2 · Unit 18 · Reading · 45 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Mark 1:1-45. Mark begins with no birth story and no prologue. Notice how quickly the scenes move, and how often the word "immediately" appears. Read it in one sitting if you can, to feel the pace.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Mark is the shortest and probably the earliest of the four Gospels. Early Christians said it was written by John Mark, a companion of Peter, and that it reflects Peter's preaching in Rome. It was written for a church that was suffering, and it presents Jesus as the strong Son of God who is also the suffering servant. Mark uses the word "immediately" (or "at once") over forty times. Things happen quickly. There is almost no talk, and much action.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "The beginning of the gospel of Jesus Christ, the Son of God" (1:1).
2. "And when he came up out of the water, immediately he saw the heavens being torn open and the Spirit descending on him like a dove" (1:10).
3. "The time is fulfilled, and the kingdom of God is at hand; repent and believe in the gospel" (1:15).
4. "Follow me, and I will make you become fishers of men" (1:17).
5. "And they were astonished at his teaching, for he taught them as one who had authority, and not as the scribes" (1:22).
6. "And rising very early in the morning, while it was still dark, he departed and went out to a desolate place, and there he prayed" (1:35).

7. “Moved with pity, he stretched out his hand and touched him and said to him, I will; be clean” (1:41).

8. “See that you say nothing to anyone” (1:44).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Mark’s first sentence is his title: “The beginning of the gospel of Jesus Christ, the Son of God.” Gospel means good news, the announcement of a victory. Mark tells us at once who Jesus is, though the people in the story will take most of the book to find out.

John the Baptist appears in the wilderness, as Isaiah promised, and says that one more powerful is coming. Jesus is baptized, and Mark says the heavens are “torn open,” a strong word, as the Spirit descends and the Father says, “You are my beloved Son; with you I am well pleased.” Immediately the Spirit drives him into the wilderness, where he is tempted by Satan for forty days. Mark gives the temptation in two verses. The battle between the Son of God and the powers of darkness has begun.

Then Jesus comes to Galilee: “The time is fulfilled, and the kingdom of God is at hand; repent and believe in the gospel.” This is the heart of his message. The long-awaited reign of God is arriving in his person. He calls Simon and Andrew, James and John, and they leave their nets at once.

In the synagogue in Capernaum, he teaches with authority, unlike the scribes, who quoted other rabbis. A man with an unclean spirit cries out, “I know who you are, the Holy One of God.” Jesus silences the demon and casts it out. The crowd is amazed. He heals Peter’s mother-in-law, and by evening the whole town is at the door. Yet early the next morning he withdraws to pray. His power flows from communion with the Father.

A leper kneels before him and says, “If you will, you can make me clean.” Moved with pity, Jesus stretches out his hand and touches him, something no one would do, and says, “I will; be clean.” The unclean person is made clean without making Jesus unclean. Then he commands the man to say nothing and to go to the priest. But the man tells everyone. This is the first appearance of a pattern in Mark that scholars call the Messianic secret: Jesus often silences demons and those he heals. We will return to why.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 40:3 and Malachi 3:1 are the prophecies Mark quotes at the start. Psalm 2:7 and Isaiah 42:1 stand behind the voice from heaven. Daniel 7 and Isaiah 52:7 are the background to the kingdom of God. Leviticus 13 and 14 give the laws of leprosy. 1 Peter 5:13 mentions Mark as

Peter's son in the faith. Acts 12:12 and Colossians 4:10 mention John Mark. Romans 1:16 says the gospel is the power of God for salvation.

STEP 6

Application

Read the chapter aloud quickly. How does the pace affect you?

Hear "repent and believe in the gospel" as a daily call, not a once-only event.

Like Jesus, find a quiet place early in the day to pray before the day's demands begin.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Repent and believe in the good news, in your own words.
- Thank Jesus that the kingdom is at hand.
- Ask him to help you follow him immediately.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 96

"The time is fulfilled, and the kingdom of God is at hand; repent and believe in the gospel."

MARK 1:15

DAY 667 · WEEK 96

Mark 1:14-15; Luke 17:20-21; 1 Corinthians 15:20-28

Inaugurated eschatology

Year 2 · Unit 18 · Doctrine · 14 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Mark 1:14-15, Luke 17:20-21, and 1 Corinthians 15:20-28. Today is a doctrinal pause on the kingdom of God as already here and not yet complete. Notice the tenses: the kingdom has come, and the kingdom will come.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Jesus began his ministry by announcing that the kingdom of God was at hand. The Jews expected the kingdom to arrive all at once, with the Messiah defeating Israel's enemies and raising the dead. Jesus said the kingdom had arrived, and yet he spoke of its future coming. Paul, in 1 Corinthians 15, describes the order of events. Theologians call this "inaugurated eschatology," or the "already and not yet."

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Now after John was arrested, Jesus came into Galilee, proclaiming the gospel of God" (Mark 1:14).
2. "The time is fulfilled, and the kingdom of God is at hand" (Mark 1:15).
3. "The kingdom of God is not coming in ways that can be observed" (Luke 17:20).
4. "For behold, the kingdom of God is in the midst of you" (Luke 17:21).
5. "But in fact Christ has been raised from the dead, the firstfruits of those who have fallen asleep" (1 Corinthians 15:20).
6. "But each in his own order: Christ the firstfruits, then at his coming those who belong to Christ" (1 Corinthians 15:23).

7. “For he must reign until he has put all his enemies under his feet” (1 Corinthians 15:25).
8. “The last enemy to be destroyed is death” (1 Corinthians 15:26).

DOCTRINAL PAUSE

Doctrinal Focus

The kingdom of God is God’s rule and reign over his creation, and in the New Testament it is both present and future. It is present because the King has come. In Jesus’ life, death, and resurrection, the decisive victory over sin, Satan, and death has been won, and the Spirit has been poured out. The powers of the age to come have broken into this age. It is future because the kingdom has not yet come in its fullness. Sin and death still operate, believers still suffer, and Christ’s enemies have not yet been finally put under his feet. The church lives between the first coming and the second, in the overlap of the ages. Biblical scholars call this the “already and not yet.” This framework fits the way the covenants unfold: the promises made to Abraham and David are fulfilled in Christ and have begun to be realized, and they will be completed when he returns. Christians have differed on the details of the end, such as the nature of the millennium in Revelation 20, but all agree that Christ will return, the dead will be raised, and God will be all in all. Until then, the church is not merely waiting. It lives as a sign of the kingdom, proclaiming the King and walking in his ways.

STEP 4

Interpretation

Mark records the opening announcement of Jesus’ public ministry. “The time is fulfilled” means that the long wait, the centuries of promises, is over. “The kingdom of God is at hand” means it has drawn near, in the person of the King. The response is to repent and believe.

Luke 17 shows another side. The Pharisees ask when the kingdom of God will come, and Jesus says it is not coming with signs to be observed. It cannot be pointed to on a map. “The kingdom of God is in the midst of you,” because the King is standing there. The kingdom is first of all a person. His healings and exorcisms are the kingdom’s invasion of the world, and when he casts out demons by the Spirit of God, then the kingdom has come upon them.

Yet the kingdom is not complete. In 1 Corinthians 15, Paul writes of the resurrection and says that Christ is the firstfruits. The firstfruits is the first part of the harvest, and it promises the rest. Christ has been raised, and those who belong to him will be raised at his coming. Then comes the end, when he delivers the kingdom to God the Father after destroying every rule and authority and power. “For he must reign until he has put all his enemies under his feet. The last enemy to be destroyed is death.” So there is a reign now, and a final victory yet to come. When all is subjected to him, the Son himself will be subject to the Father, “that God may be all in all.”

This has practical effects. Because the kingdom has come, we have forgiveness, the Spirit, and a new identity, and we can obey. Because it has not fully come, we still groan, suffer, and wait, and we do not expect heaven on earth in this age. We are neither triumphalists nor pessimists. We live with joyful patience, praying "Your kingdom come," and working in hope because we know how the story ends.

STEP 5

Connection

Daniel 2:44 and 7:13-14 promise an everlasting kingdom. Matthew 12:28 says that if Jesus casts out demons by the Spirit, the kingdom has come. Matthew 6:10 teaches us to pray for the kingdom to come. Romans 8:18-25 describes the groaning of creation as we wait. Hebrews 2:8 says we do not yet see everything in subjection to him. Ephesians 1:13-14 calls the Spirit a guarantee of our inheritance. Revelation 11:15 and 21:1-5 describe the final arrival.

STEP 6

Application

Pray "Your kingdom come" today, thinking of both the ways it has come and the ways it has not.

Where do you see signs of the kingdom in your church or neighborhood? Thank God for them.

When you are discouraged by the world, remember that Christ must reign until every enemy, including death, is under his feet.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God that in Jesus the kingdom has come.

Thank him for the firstfruits of the resurrection.

Ask him to teach you to live between the already and the not yet.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 96

“The time is fulfilled, and the kingdom of God is at hand; repent and believe in the gospel.”

MARK 1:15

DAY 668 · WEEK 96

Mark 2:1-3:35

Controversies; new wineskins; the true family of Jesus

Year 2 · Unit 18 · Reading · 63 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Mark 2:1-3:35. A paralyzed man is lowered through a roof, Jesus eats with sinners, the Sabbath controversies begin, and opposition hardens. Notice who Jesus welcomes and who rejects him.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

These two chapters contain a series of five conflict stories in Galilee. In each, the religious leaders challenge Jesus' authority: to forgive sins, to eat with sinners, to set aside fasting, and to interpret the Sabbath. By the end of chapter 3, the Pharisees are plotting with the Herodians to destroy him. Mark places the opposition early to show that the road to the cross begins here.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Son, your sins are forgiven" (2:5).
2. "But that you may know that the Son of Man has authority on earth to forgive sins" (2:10).
3. "Those who are well have no need of a physician, but those who are sick. I came not to call the righteous, but sinners" (2:17).
4. "And no one puts new wine into old wineskins" (2:22).
5. "The Sabbath was made for man, not man for the Sabbath" (2:27).
6. "And he looked around at them with anger, grieved at their hardness of heart" (3:5).
7. "Whoever blasphemes against the Holy Spirit never has forgiveness, but is guilty of an eternal sin" (3:29).

8 “For whoever does the will of God, he is my brother and sister and mother” (3:35).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Four friends bring a paralyzed man to Jesus, and when they cannot get through the crowd, they dig through the roof. Jesus sees their faith and says to the man, “Son, your sins are forgiven.” The scribes think, “Who can forgive sins but God alone?” They are right about the principle, and that is the point. Jesus then heals the man to prove that the Son of Man has authority on earth to forgive sins. The man’s greatest need was forgiveness, and Jesus addressed that first.

He calls Levi, a tax collector, and eats with tax collectors and sinners. When the scribes complain, he says, “Those who are well have no need of a physician.” He has come for the sick. Anyone who thinks they are well will miss him.

When asked why his disciples do not fast, he says the bridegroom is with them. A wedding is no time for fasting. The old way and the new cannot be patched together: new wine requires new wineskins. The new covenant does not fit into the old forms. This is a key statement of the discontinuity in the covenants. What Jesus brings is new.

The Sabbath conflicts follow. His disciples pick grain on the Sabbath, and Jesus says, “The Sabbath was made for man, not man for the Sabbath. So the Son of Man is lord even of the Sabbath.” In the synagogue he heals a man with a withered hand, and asks whether it is lawful to do good or harm on the Sabbath. They are silent. He looks at them with anger, “grieved at their hardness of heart.” Jesus is angry and sad at the same time. The Pharisees go out and plot with the Herodians how to destroy him.

In chapter 3, crowds follow him, and he appoints twelve to be with him and to be sent out. His family thinks he is out of his mind. The scribes from Jerusalem say he casts out demons by Beelzebul. Jesus responds that a house divided cannot stand, and warns that to attribute the Spirit’s work to Satan is an unforgivable blasphemy, a settled refusal to see God’s work as good. Finally, when his mother and brothers arrive, he looks at those sitting around him and says, “Here are my mother and my brothers! Whoever does the will of God, he is my brother and sister and mother.” The new family of God is defined by obedience to him.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 43:25 says God alone blots out transgressions. Psalm 103:3 says the LORD forgives all your iniquity. Hosea 6:6 is the mercy-over-sacrifice theme. 1 Samuel 21:1-6 is David and the bread. Exodus 20:8-11 and Deuteronomy 5:12-15 are the Sabbath commands. Jeremiah 31:31-

34 promised a new covenant. Hebrews 8:13 says the first covenant is becoming obsolete. Galatians 3:26-29 and Ephesians 2:19 describe the new family of God.

STEP 6

Application

Think of those who brought you to Jesus. Thank God for them, and ask whom you could carry to him.

Reflect on whether you are a patient who needs the physician. Admit your need.

Ask what "doing the will of God" looks like in your family and church this week.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for authority to forgive sins, and for forgiving yours.

Thank him for coming for sinners.

Ask him to make you new wine, ready for what he is doing.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 96

"The time is fulfilled, and the kingdom of God is at hand; repent and believe in the gospel."

MARK 1:15

DAY 669 · WEEK 96

Mark 4:1-5:43

Parables; the storm; the Gerasene; Jairus's daughter

Year 2 · Unit 18 · Reading · 84 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Mark 4:1-5:43. Jesus teaches in parables, stills a storm, frees a demon-possessed man, and heals two women. It is a chapter of authority over the seed, the sea, the spirits, sickness, and death. Notice the repeated question of faith and fear.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Jesus sits in a boat by the Sea of Galilee and teaches a large crowd on the shore. Mark records only a few parables, but they are key to the kingdom. Then comes a day of wonders. Jesus crosses the lake with his disciples, and in the span of two chapters demonstrates his authority over nature, demons, disease, and death.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Listen! Behold, a sower went out to sow" (4:3).
2. "He who has ears to hear, let him hear" (4:9).
3. "It is like a grain of mustard seed, which, when sown on the ground, is the smallest of all the seeds on earth" (4:31).
4. "Peace! Be still!" (4:39).
5. "Who then is this, that even the wind and the sea obey him?" (4:41).
6. "Go home to your friends and tell them how much the Lord has done for you, and how he has had mercy on you" (5:19).
7. "Do not fear, only believe" (5:36).
8. "Little girl, I say to you, arise" (5:41).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The parable of the sower is the first of the parables and a key to the rest. A sower scatters seed on four kinds of ground: the path, rocky ground, thorny ground, and good soil. The seed is the word of God. The first three soils show failures: the word is snatched away, withers without roots, or is choked by worries and riches. The good soil hears, accepts, and bears fruit, thirty, sixty, and a hundredfold. Jesus says the parables are given so that those with ears hear, and those without do not understand. They sift. He then tells of the seed growing secretly and the mustard seed. The kingdom starts small, grows by God's power, and ends large.

That evening, Jesus says, "Let us go across to the other side." A great windstorm arises, and the boat is filling with water. Jesus is asleep on a cushion in the stern. The disciples wake him: "Teacher, do you not care that we are perishing?" He rebukes the wind and says to the sea, "Peace! Be still!" There is a great calm. He asks, "Why are you so afraid? Have you still no faith?" And they are filled with great fear and say, "Who then is this, that even the wind and the sea obey him?" Their fear of the storm has turned into awe at him.

On the far shore, in Gentile territory, a man lives among the tombs, so possessed that no one can bind him. He is called Legion. Jesus casts the demons into a herd of pigs, and the man is found clothed and in his right mind. The townspeople ask Jesus to leave. The man begs to go with Jesus, but Jesus tells him to go home and tell what the Lord has done. He proclaims it in the Decapolis, ten cities of Gentiles.

Back across the lake, Jairus, a synagogue ruler, begs Jesus to heal his dying daughter. On the way, a woman with a twelve-year flow of blood touches his garment and is healed. Jesus stops and says, "Daughter, your faith has made you well; go in peace." Then news comes that Jairus's daughter is dead. Jesus says, "Do not fear, only believe." He takes her hand and says, "Talitha cumi," "Little girl, I say to you, arise." She gets up and walks. Jesus is the Lord of life.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 55:10-11 says the word will not return empty. Ezekiel 17:22-24 and Daniel 4:10-12 use the image of a great tree. Psalm 65:7, 89:9, and 107:29 show the LORD stilling the sea. Jonah 1 is another storm and sleeping man. Isaiah 65:4 mentions tombs and swine. Leviticus 15:25-30 describes the uncleanness of the woman's bleeding. 2 Kings 4 tells of Elisha raising a child. 1 Corinthians 15:26 says the last enemy to be destroyed is death.

STEP 6

Application

Ask which soil you are right now. What thorns might be choking the word in you?

Name a storm you face, and hear Jesus say “Peace! Be still!” to it.

Like the healed man, tell someone what the Lord has done for you this week.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to make your heart good soil.
- Tell Jesus about a storm you are in.
- Thank him that he is Lord of both.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 96

“The time is fulfilled, and the kingdom of God is at hand; repent and believe in the gospel.”

MARK 1:15

DAY 670 · WEEK 96

Mark 6:1-56

Nazareth; the Twelve; John beheaded; the feeding; walking on water

Year 2 · Unit 18 · Reading · 56 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Mark 6:1-56. Jesus is rejected in Nazareth, sends out the Twelve, John the Baptist is beheaded, five thousand are fed, and Jesus walks on the sea. Notice the contrast between those who reject Jesus and those who receive him.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Jesus returns to his hometown of Nazareth, where he grew up, and meets disbelief. He sends the Twelve out on mission. While they are gone, Mark inserts the story of John's death, a dark foreshadowing of Jesus' own. When the Twelve return, Jesus feeds a crowd of five thousand, and that night walks on water. Mark often sandwiches one story within another to draw out meaning.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "A prophet is not without honor, except in his hometown and among his relatives and in his own household" (6:4).
2. "And he marveled because of their unbelief" (6:6).
3. "And he called the twelve and began to send them out two by two" (6:7).
4. "So they went out and proclaimed that people should repent" (6:12).
5. "When he went ashore he saw a great crowd, and he had compassion on them, because they were like sheep without a shepherd" (6:34).
6. "And taking the five loaves and the two fish he looked up to heaven and said a blessing and broke the loaves" (6:41).
7. "Take heart; it is I. Do not be afraid" (6:50).

8 “For they did not understand about the loaves, but their hearts were hardened” (6:52).

STEP 4

Interpretation

In Nazareth, the people who know Jesus best cannot see who he is. “Is not this the carpenter, the son of Mary?” They take offense at him. Jesus says, “A prophet is not without honor, except in his hometown.” Mark says, “He could do no mighty work there,” except to heal a few. Familiarity and unbelief closed their eyes, and “he marveled because of their unbelief.” Even Jesus was astonished at the hardness of human hearts.

He sends out the Twelve two by two with authority over unclean spirits, with only a staff and sandals. They proclaim repentance, cast out demons, and anoint the sick with oil. The mission of Jesus is multiplied through his disciples.

Mark then tells of Herod’s birthday banquet. Herod had imprisoned John for condemning his marriage to his brother’s wife. Herodias holds a grudge, and when her daughter dances and pleases Herod, he rashly promises her anything. At her mother’s request she asks for John’s head on a platter. Herod is distressed but keeps his oath, and John is beheaded. The faithful prophet dies at the whim of a weak king. It is the shadow of the cross.

When the apostles return, Jesus takes them to a desolate place to rest, but a crowd runs ahead. Seeing them, he has compassion because they are like sheep without a shepherd. He teaches, and when evening comes, the disciples suggest sending them away. Jesus says, “You give them something to eat.” They have five loaves and two fish. He looks up to heaven, blesses and breaks, and gives to the disciples to distribute. All eat and are satisfied, with twelve baskets left. It echoes the LORD feeding Israel in the wilderness and Elisha’s miracle, but it is greater.

That night the disciples are straining at the oars against the wind. Jesus comes to them, walking on the sea. “He meant to pass by them.” This is the language of a theophany, like God passing by Moses. They think he is a ghost. He says, “Take heart; it is I. Do not be afraid,” and the wind ceases. Mark comments that they were astonished, for they had not understood about the loaves, “but their hearts were hardened.” They saw but did not see. Mark is preparing for the question in chapter 8: who is Jesus?

STEP 5

Connection

Numbers 27:17 and Ezekiel 34 speak of sheep without a shepherd. Psalm 23 shows the shepherd providing a table. Exodus 16 and 2 Kings 4:42-44 record bread in the wilderness. Job 9:8 says God alone treads on the waves of the sea. Exodus 33:19-23 and 34:6 are God

passing by Moses. Isaiah 43:2 and Psalm 77:19 speak of God's path through the waters. Hebrews 11:36-38 mentions the faithful who suffered.

STEP 6

Application

Is there someone close to you who has trouble seeing Jesus because they know you too well? Pray for them.

Look at the little you have, your five loaves, and offer it to Jesus.

When you are rowing against the wind, listen for "Take heart; it is I."

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Confess where your heart has been hard like those who rejected him.

Ask him to teach you to trust him on the water.

Thank him for feeding you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 96

"The time is fulfilled, and the kingdom of God is at hand; repent and believe in the gospel."

MARK 1:15

DAY 671 · WEEK 96

Psalm 107:23-43

God stills the storm

Year 2 · Unit 18 · Psalm · 21 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 107:23-43. This is the middle of a great psalm of thanksgiving for God's rescue. Read the storm at sea (vv. 23 to 32) and notice how it echoes Mark 4. You first met Psalm 107 as a song of those brought back from exile; today you look at its sea-storm section alone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 107 describes four groups of people whom the LORD rescued: wanderers in the desert, prisoners, the sick, and sailors. Each cries to the LORD in trouble, he delivers them, and the refrain says they should give thanks. Today's reading covers the fourth group, the sailors in the storm, and then a closing section on how God reverses fortunes. It sits well with the stilling of the storm in Mark 4 and the walk on water in Mark 6.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "They saw the deeds of the LORD, his wondrous works in the deep" (v. 24).
2. "For he commanded and raised the stormy wind, which lifted up the waves of the sea" (v. 25).
3. "They reeled and staggered like drunken men and were at their wits" end' (v. 27).
4. "Then they cried to the LORD in their trouble, and he delivered them from their distress" (v. 28).
5. "He made the storm be still, and the waves of the sea were hushed" (v. 29).
6. "Then they were glad that the waters were quiet, and he brought them to their desired haven" (v. 30).

7. “Let them thank the LORD for his steadfast love, for his wondrous works to the children of men!” (v. 31).

8. “Whoever is wise, let him attend to these things; let them consider the steadfast love of the LORD” (v. 43).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The sailors go down to the sea in ships, doing business on the great waters. They see the wonders of the LORD in the deep. But the same God who made the sea can raise the storm. “For he commanded and raised the stormy wind.” The storm is not outside his control. The waves lift them to heaven and drop them to the depths, and “their courage melted away in their evil plight.” They reel like drunken men and are at their wits’ end. The Hebrew says their wisdom was swallowed up. There is nothing left that they can do.

“Then they cried to the LORD in their trouble, and he delivered them from their distress.” It is the simplest and most powerful pattern of the psalm. When we reach the end of ourselves, we can cry to him. “He made the storm be still, and the waves of the sea were hushed.” The word for still is the word for a whisper. At his command the storm becomes a murmur. “Then they were glad that the waters were quiet, and he brought them to their desired haven.”

Compare Mark 4. The disciples, some of them seasoned fishermen, were at their wits’ end. They cried out. And Jesus stood and said, “Peace! Be still!” The disciples asked, “Who is this?” Psalm 107 supplies the answer: this is the LORD who commands the stormy wind and makes the storm be still. Only God does that, and Jesus does it.

The refrain returns: “Let them thank the LORD for his steadfast love.” Thanksgiving is the right response to rescue. Let them extol him in the congregation of the people.

The last verses show a God who turns rivers into a desert and a desert into pools of water, who lifts the needy out of affliction and makes their families like flocks. The upright see it and are glad, and iniquity shuts its mouth. The final line asks us to be wise: consider the steadfast love of the LORD.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 65:7 and 89:9 speak of the LORD stilling the sea. Jonah 1:4-16 describes a storm that stops at God’s word. Job 38:8-11 shows God setting limits to the sea. Isaiah 43:2 promises to be with us through the waters. Mark 4:35-41 and Matthew 8:23-27 are the stilling of the storm. Acts 27 describes Paul’s storm at sea. Hebrews 6:19 calls hope an anchor for the soul.

STEP 6

Application

Where are you at your wits' end? Cry to the LORD in it, as the sailors did.

After a deliverance, remember to give thanks. Write down a recent rescue and thank him for it.

Read the Mark 4 story again beside this psalm, and ask who Jesus must be to do what only God can do.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Cry to God from your own storm.
- Thank him for stilling the storm to a whisper.
- Thank him for bringing you to your desired haven.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 96

"The time is fulfilled, and the kingdom of God is at hand; repent and believe in the gospel."

MARK 1:15

DAY 672 · WEEK 96

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 18 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Mark 1:15 slowly, several times, and say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"The time is fulfilled, and the kingdom of God is at hand; repent and believe in the gospel."

MARK 1:15

REST

Meditation

These are the first recorded words of Jesus' public ministry in Mark, and they sum up his whole message.

"The time is fulfilled." The waiting is over. For centuries the prophets had promised a day when God would rescue his people and rule. That day has arrived. Everything in the Old Testament was moving toward this moment.

"And the kingdom of God is at hand." The kingdom is God's reign. It is near, not as an idea, but as a person. The King is standing in Galilee.

"Repent." To repent is to change direction, to turn from sin and self toward God. It is not just feeling sorry. It is a change of mind that leads to a change of life.

"And believe in the gospel." To believe is to trust. The gospel is the good news that the King has come to save. The proper response to good news is to receive it with trust.

Notice the two verbs go together. We repent and believe. They are two sides of one turning. This is how a Christian life begins, and it is how it continues.

When you wonder where to begin each day, say this verse. Turn to him again.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you began the Gospel of Mark, the fast-moving account of the servant King. In chapter 1 you saw Jesus baptized, tempted, and announcing that the kingdom of God is at hand. Your doctrinal pause on the kingdom taught you to see it as already here and not yet complete. In chapters 2 and 3 he forgave a paralyzed man, ate with sinners, and said new wine needs new wineskins. In chapters 4 to 6 you watched him teach about the seed, still a storm, free a demoniac, raise Jairus's daughter, be rejected in Nazareth, and feed five thousand. Psalm 107 helped you hear the stilling of the storm as the LORD's own work. Through it all, Mark kept asking who this is.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Jesus began his ministry with the words "Repent and believe in the gospel." What does repenting and believing look like in the details of your life this week?

The kingdom is both already here and not yet complete. Where do you see signs of it now, and where are you still waiting?

The disciples asked "Who then is this, that even the wind and the sea obey him?" How would you answer that question after what you have read this week?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Repent and believe the gospel, in your own words.

Thank Jesus for his authority.

Rest in his kingdom.

DAY 673 · WEEK 97

Psalm 89:1-18

I will sing of the steadfast love of the LORD

Year 2 · Unit 18 · Psalm · 18 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 89:1-18. The psalmist sings of God's steadfast love and his covenant with David. Read it with Mark's question in mind: who is the Son of David?

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 89 is a maskil of Ethan the Ezrahite. It was probably written after the Davidic dynasty fell, since the second half (which we do not read today) laments that God seems to have rejected his anointed. But the first half sings of God's faithfulness and the covenant promise to David. Reading this part prepares us for Mark, where the question of David's son and the Christ is about to be asked directly.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "I will sing of the steadfast love of the LORD, forever; with my mouth I will make known your faithfulness to all generations" (v. 1).
2. "You have said, I have made a covenant with my chosen one; I have sworn to David my servant" (v. 3).
3. "I will establish your offspring forever, and build your throne for all generations" (v. 4).
4. "For who in the skies can be compared to the LORD?" (v. 6).
5. "O LORD God of hosts, who is mighty as you are, O LORD, with your faithfulness all around you?" (v. 8).
6. "Righteousness and justice are the foundation of your throne; steadfast love and faithfulness go before you" (v. 14).

7. “Blessed are the people who know the festal shout, who walk, O LORD, in the light of your face” (v. 15).

8. “For our shield belongs to the LORD, our king to the Holy One of Israel” (v. 18).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm opens with a vow to sing. “I will sing of the steadfast love of the LORD, forever.” Notice the two words that run through the whole psalm: steadfast love and faithfulness. They appear again and again. Ethan sings that God’s love is built up forever and his faithfulness is established in the heavens.

Then comes the covenant. God said, “I have made a covenant with my chosen one; I have sworn to David my servant: I will establish your offspring forever, and build your throne for all generations.” These words echo 2 Samuel 7, the promise of a son of David whose throne would last forever. The psalmist rests the whole praise on this promise.

The psalm then lifts our eyes to the greatness of the LORD. The heavens praise his wonders, and in the assembly of the holy ones he is feared. No one among the heavenly beings is like him. He rules the raging of the sea, and when its waves rise, he stills them. Rahab, the sea monster, he crushed. The heavens and the earth are his, the north and the south he created. His arm is mighty, his hand strong. Here again is the Psalm 107 theme: the LORD stills the sea, and in Mark, Jesus does the same.

Verse 14 gives the foundation of God’s throne: “Righteousness and justice are the foundation of your throne; steadfast love and faithfulness go before you.” God’s rule is not arbitrary. It is built on righteousness, and it is led by love. Blessed are the people who know the festal shout and walk in the light of his face. They rejoice in his name all day and are exalted in his righteousness. Their shield, their king, belongs to the LORD.

Read the psalm in light of Mark 8 to 12. Peter will say, “You are the Christ,” and Bartimaeus will cry, “Son of David, have mercy on me!” The promise of 2 Samuel 7 is held in the hands of the one the Gospel names as the Son of David. When the second half of the psalm asks, “Where is your steadfast love of old, which by your faithfulness you swore to David?”, the answer is Jesus. The throne of David is established forever, in the risen Christ.

STEP 5

Connection

2 Samuel 7:8-16 and 1 Chronicles 17 give the Davidic covenant. Psalm 132:11-18 repeats the oath to David. Psalm 110 speaks of the Lord’s king at his right hand. Isaiah 9:6-7 promises an everlasting throne. Luke 1:32-33 echoes Psalm 89 in the angel’s words to Mary. Acts 2:29-36

says David's promised descendant is the risen Jesus. Romans 1:3-4 says Jesus was descended from David and declared Son of God by the resurrection. Revelation 22:16 calls Jesus the root and descendant of David.

STEP 6

Application

Sing or speak aloud the opening vow: "I will sing of the steadfast love of the LORD, forever." Tell someone of God's faithfulness this week.

Notice that the foundation of God's rule is righteousness and justice. How does that comfort you when the world feels unjust?

Pray for the people of God to walk in the light of his face.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Sing of God's steadfast love, in your own words.
- Thank him for his covenant with David.
- Ask him to help you make known his faithfulness to those who come after you.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 97

"And Jesus said to him, If you can! All things are possible for one who believes."

MARK 9:23

DAY 674 · WEEK 97

Mark 7:1-8:38

Defilement; the Syrophoenician woman; Peter's confession

Year 2 · Unit 18 · Reading · 75 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Mark 7:1-8:38. Jesus teaches about what defiles, heals a Gentile woman's daughter, feeds four thousand, and then asks his disciples, "Who do you say that I am?" This is the turning point of the Gospel. Read Peter's confession and what follows slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Pharisees and scribes come from Jerusalem to challenge Jesus about ceremonial washing. He turns the conversation to the heart. Then he travels north into Gentile territory, Tyre, Sidon, and the Decapolis, and heals Gentiles. Mark 8:27-30 is the center of the Gospel. The first half asks, who is this? The second half answers, the Christ who must suffer.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "This people honors me with their lips, but their heart is far from me" (7:6).
2. "There is nothing outside a person that by going into him can defile him, but the things that come out of a person are what defile him" (7:15).
3. "Yes, Lord; even the dogs under the table eat the children's crumbs" (7:28).
4. "He has done all things well. He even makes the deaf hear and the mute speak" (7:37).
5. "But who do you say that I am?" Peter answered him, "You are the Christ" (8:29).
6. "And he began to teach them that the Son of Man must suffer many things and be rejected by the elders and the chief priests and the scribes and be killed, and after three days rise again" (8:31).
7. "If anyone would come after me, let him deny himself and take up his cross and follow me" (8:34).

8 “For what does it profit a man to gain the whole world and forfeit his soul?” (8:36).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The Pharisees ask why Jesus’ disciples eat with unwashed hands. Jesus quotes Isaiah: “This people honors me with their lips, but their heart is far from me.” They have set aside the commandment of God to hold to human tradition. Then he teaches the crowd that it is not what goes into a person that defiles him but what comes out of the heart: evil thoughts, sexual immorality, theft, murder, adultery, covetousness. The problem is not external but internal. Mark adds a parenthetical comment: “Thus he declared all foods clean.” The Old Testament dietary laws, which marked Israel off from the nations, have fulfilled their purpose.

Jesus goes to Tyre, where a Syrophoenician woman, a Gentile, begs him to cast a demon out of her daughter. He says, “Let the children be fed first,” meaning Israel has priority in the history of salvation. She answers with great faith and wit: “Yes, Lord; yet even the dogs under the table eat the children’s crumbs.” Jesus says, “For this statement you may go your way; the demon has left your daughter.” She would not be turned away. Then he heals a deaf man, and the crowd says, “He has done all things well.” He feeds four thousand, probably Gentiles, and warns the disciples about the leaven of the Pharisees.

Then comes the turning point. At Caesarea Philippi, Jesus asks, “Who do people say that I am?” They give the answers: John, Elijah, one of the prophets. Then, “But who do you say that I am?” Peter answers, “You are the Christ.” This is the first time any human in Mark names Jesus rightly. And Jesus immediately begins to teach what kind of Christ he is: one who must suffer, be rejected, be killed, and rise again.

Peter takes him aside and rebukes him. Jesus turns, looks at his disciples, and says to Peter, “Get behind me, Satan! For you are not setting your mind on the things of God, but on the things of man.” Peter wanted a Messiah without a cross. Jesus insists on the cross, and calls everyone who follows him to the same road: “Let him deny himself and take up his cross and follow me.” For whoever loses his life for the sake of Jesus and the gospel will save it. “For what does it profit a man to gain the whole world and forfeit his soul?”

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 29:13 is the verse Jesus quotes. Leviticus 11 gives the dietary laws, and Acts 10:9-16 and Romans 14:14 show that they are no longer binding. Jeremiah 17:9 says the heart is deceitful. Isaiah 35:5-6 promises the deaf will hear. Psalm 118:22 and Isaiah 53 point to the rejected,

suffering Messiah. Luke 9:23-25 and Matthew 16:24-26 are parallels to the call to take up the cross. Galatians 2:20 says we have been crucified with Christ.

STEP 6

Application

Ask whether your heart is far from God even as your lips honor him. Confess it.

Take Peter's confession as your own: "You are the Christ." Then ask whether you are willing to follow the Christ who suffers.

Learn from the Syrophoenician woman's persistence in prayer.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Confess who you believe Jesus is.
- Ask him to purify your heart.
- Thank him for hearing people like the Syrophoenician woman.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 97

"And Jesus said to him, If you can! All things are possible for one who believes."

MARK 9:23

DAY 675 · WEEK 97

Mark 9:1-50

The Transfiguration; the demonized boy; greatness in the Kingdom

Year 2 · Unit 18 · Reading · 50 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Mark 9:1-50. The Transfiguration, a father's honest cry, a second prediction of the passion, and teaching on greatness and sin. Read verses 14 to 29 slowly, the story of the father and his son.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Six days after Peter's confession, Jesus takes Peter, James, and John up a high mountain, and there they see his glory. They come down to find the other disciples in a dispute over a boy they could not heal. Throughout the chapter, the disciples do not understand. Jesus speaks again of his death, and they argue about who is the greatest.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "This is my beloved Son; listen to him" (9:7).
2. "And Jesus said to him, If you can! All things are possible for one who believes" (9:23).
3. "I believe; help my unbelief!" (9:24).
4. "This kind cannot be driven out by anything but prayer" (9:29).
5. "The Son of Man will be delivered into the hands of men, and they will kill him. And when he is killed, after three days he will rise" (9:31).
6. "If anyone would be first, he must be last of all and servant of all" (9:35).
7. "Whoever causes one of these little ones who believe in me to sin, it would be better for him if a great millstone were hung around his neck and he were cast into the sea" (9:42).
8. "Have salt in yourselves, and be at peace with one another" (9:50).

STEP 4

Interpretation

On the mountain, Jesus is transfigured. His clothes become radiant, whiter than anyone could bleach them. Elijah and Moses appear and talk with him. Peter, terrified, suggests building three tents. A cloud overshadows them, and a voice from the cloud says, "This is my beloved Son; listen to him." Suddenly they see only Jesus. The Law (Moses) and the Prophets (Elijah) bear witness to Jesus, and then they fade. The Father's command is to listen to the Son. On the way down, Jesus tells them not to tell anyone until the Son of Man has risen from the dead. They do not understand what rising from the dead means.

At the foot of the mountain, a father has brought his son, who has a spirit that seizes him, throws him down, and makes him mute. The disciples could not cast it out. The father says to Jesus, "If you can do anything, have compassion on us and help us." Jesus says, "If you can! All things are possible for one who believes." And the father cries out one of the most honest prayers in the Bible: "I believe; help my unbelief!" He has faith, but it is mixed with doubt, and he brings both to Jesus. Jesus does not reject him. He rebukes the spirit, and the boy is freed. When the disciples ask why they could not, Jesus says, "This kind cannot be driven out by anything but prayer."

Jesus again speaks of his death and resurrection, and they do not understand and are afraid to ask. Instead, on the road they have argued about who is greatest. Jesus sits down, calls the Twelve, and says, "If anyone would be first, he must be last of all and servant of all." He takes a child in his arms and says that whoever receives such a child in his name receives him.

The chapter ends with stern warnings. John reports someone casting out demons in Jesus' name who was not following them, and Jesus says, "Whoever is not against us is for us." Then he warns against causing little ones to stumble, and calls his followers to take radical action against sin: if your hand or foot or eye causes you to sin, cut it off or pluck it out. The point is not self-mutilation but the seriousness of sin. "Have salt in yourselves, and be at peace with one another."

STEP 5

Connection

Exodus 24:15-18 and 34:29-35 describe Moses on the mountain in glory. Malachi 4:5 promises Elijah. Deuteronomy 18:15 says to listen to the prophet like Moses. 2 Peter 1:16-18 is Peter's reflection on the Transfiguration. Luke 9:31 says Moses and Elijah spoke of his departure. Psalm 73:23-26 is a prayer of the weak but trusting. Jude 22 calls us to have mercy on those who doubt. Philippians 2:3-8 shows the servant attitude.

STEP 6

Application

Pray the father's prayer from your heart: "I believe; help my unbelief!" Be honest about both.

Listen to Jesus today. Read one of his teachings in the Gospels slowly.

Ask where you have been arguing about greatness, and take the servant's place.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to help you listen to his beloved Son.
- Say, "I believe; help my unbelief."
- Ask him to teach you to pray.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 97

"And Jesus said to him, If you can! All things are possible for one who believes."

MARK 9:23

DAY 676 · WEEK 97

Mark 10:1-52

Divorce; children; the rich man; Bartimaeus

Year 2 · Unit 18 · Reading · 52 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Mark 10:1-52. Teaching on marriage and divorce, welcoming children, the rich man who walked away, the third prediction of the passion, a request for places of honor, and the healing of Bartimaeus. Verse 45 is the key verse of the Gospel and the memory verse of this unit.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Jesus is on the way to Jerusalem. In this chapter, he teaches on the foundations of life in the kingdom: marriage, children, wealth, and power. Each teaching reverses the world's values. And each is followed by a picture of the cross: "The Son of Man came to serve and to give his life." The chapter ends with a blind man who sees, just before the final approach to Jerusalem.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "What therefore God has joined together, let not man separate" (10:9).
2. "Let the children come to me; do not hinder them, for to such belongs the kingdom of God" (10:14).
3. "You lack one thing: go, sell all that you have and give to the poor, and you will have treasure in heaven; and come, follow me" (10:21).
4. "With man it is impossible, but not with God. For all things are possible with God" (10:27).
5. "Whoever would be great among you must be your servant" (10:43).

6. “For even the Son of Man came not to be served but to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for many” (10:45).
7. “Jesus, Son of David, have mercy on me!” (10:47).
8. “Go your way; your faith has made you well” (10:52).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The Pharisees test Jesus on divorce. He points back to creation: from the beginning, God made them male and female, and the two become one flesh. “What therefore God has joined together, let not man separate.” Moses permitted divorce because of hardness of heart, but that was not God’s original design. In the house, he tells the disciples that divorce and remarriage amount to adultery. Christians have differed on how to apply this in painful situations, but the high view of marriage is clear.

Parents bring their children for Jesus to touch, and the disciples rebuke them. Jesus is indignant: “Let the children come to me; do not hinder them.” To receive the kingdom like a child, in dependence, is the only way to enter. He takes them in his arms and blesses them.

A rich man runs up and kneels: “Good Teacher, what must I do to inherit eternal life?” Jesus tests him with the commandments, and the man says he has kept them all. “And Jesus, looking at him, loved him.” Then he says, “You lack one thing: go, sell all that you have and give to the poor, and you will have treasure in heaven; and come, follow me.” The man’s face falls and he goes away sorrowful, for he had great possessions. Jesus does not make this a rule for everyone, but he exposes the idol of this man. It is hard for the rich to enter the kingdom. The disciples are astonished, and ask, “Then who can be saved?” Jesus looks at them: “With man it is impossible, but not with God.” Salvation is God’s work.

For the third time, Jesus tells them plainly what will happen in Jerusalem. And again they miss it. James and John ask for the best seats in his glory. The others are indignant. Jesus gathers them and says that the rulers of the Gentiles lord it over them, “But it shall not be so among you. Whoever would be great among you must be your servant.” Then comes the key verse: “For even the Son of Man came not to be served but to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for many.” The word ransom is the price paid to free a slave or captive. Jesus gives his life as the price. The “many” is a Semitic expression for a vast number. This verse is the theological center of Mark, and a statement of substitution.

At Jericho, blind Bartimaeus calls out, “Jesus, Son of David, have mercy on me!” The crowd tries to silence him, and he cries louder. Jesus stops, calls him, and asks, “What do you want me to do for you?” “Rabbi, let me recover my sight.” “Go your way; your faith has made you

well." Immediately he receives his sight and follows Jesus on the way. It is the last healing in Mark, and the first time anyone openly calls Jesus Son of David. The blind man sees what the disciples cannot.

STEP 5

Connection

Genesis 1:27 and 2:24 are the creation texts Jesus cites. Deuteronomy 24:1-4 is the Mosaic provision. Isaiah 53:10-12 says the servant makes many to be accounted righteous and bears the sin of many. Psalm 49:7-9 says no one can ransom another. 1 Timothy 2:5-6 says Christ gave himself as a ransom for all. Titus 2:14 and 1 Peter 1:18-19 speak of redemption. Philippians 2:5-8 shows his servant mind. Luke 18:35-43 parallels the story of the blind man.

STEP 6

Application

Memorize Mark 10:45. It is the memory verse of the unit. Say it every morning this week.

Ask what you cling to that keeps you from following Jesus fully. Pray over it.

Like Bartimaeus, call out to Jesus when others tell you to be quiet.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for giving his life as a ransom for many.

Tell him what you are tempted to hold on to, like the rich man.

Ask him to open your eyes like Bartimaeus.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 97

"And Jesus said to him, If you can! All things are possible for one who believes."

MARK 9:23

DAY 677 · WEEK 97

Mark 11:1-12:44

The Entry; the Temple; controversies; the widow's offering

Year 2 · Unit 18 · Reading · 90 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Mark 11:1-12:44. The Entry into Jerusalem, the cursing of the fig tree, the cleansing of the temple, and a series of controversies in the temple courts, ending with the widow's offering. Notice how Jesus answers each question and then asks his own.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Mark has taken ten chapters to bring Jesus to Jerusalem, and now he slows down: more than a third of the Gospel is devoted to this last week. Jesus rides in on a colt, goes into the temple, and curses a fig tree, using it as a sign of judgment on a barren temple. Then he teaches in the temple courts, where various groups try to trap him.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Hosanna! Blessed is he who comes in the name of the Lord!" (11:9).
2. "Is it not written, My house shall be called a house of prayer for all the nations? But you have made it a den of robbers" (11:17).
3. "Have faith in God" (11:22).
4. "And whenever you stand praying, forgive, if you have anything against anyone, so that your Father also who is in heaven may forgive you your trespasses" (11:25).
5. "The stone that the builders rejected has become the cornerstone" (12:10).
6. "And you shall love the Lord your God with all your heart and with all your soul and with all your mind and with all your strength" (12:30).
7. "You shall love your neighbor as yourself" (12:31).

8 “Truly, I say to you, this poor widow has put in more than all those who are contributing to the offering box” (12:43).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Jesus sends two disciples for a colt, and he enters Jerusalem to the shouts of the crowd. Mark’s entry is quiet compared to the others. Jesus enters the temple, looks around at everything, and leaves, since it is already late. The next morning he curses a barren fig tree, and then he cleanses the temple, driving out the buyers and sellers. The fig tree is wrapped around the temple scene: Mark places the cursing before and the withering after, so that the barren tree interprets what happens in the temple. The temple was supposed to be a house of prayer for all nations. Instead, the outer court, the only place Gentiles could pray, was filled with commerce. The leaders hear and seek to destroy him.

In the temple courts, they challenge his authority. He answers with a question about John’s baptism, and they cannot answer. Then he tells the parable of the tenants: the owner of a vineyard sends servants, and the tenants beat and kill them, and finally he sends his beloved son, and they kill him. It is clear to the leaders that he is speaking about them. Jesus quotes Psalm 118: “The stone that the builders rejected has become the cornerstone.”

The Pharisees and Herodians ask about paying taxes to Caesar, and the Sadducees ask about the resurrection. Jesus answers both: “Render to Caesar the things that are Caesar’s, and to God the things that are God’s.” And the God of Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob “is not God of the dead, but of the living.” A scribe asks which commandment is the most important. Jesus answers with the Shema and Leviticus 19: love God with all your heart, soul, mind, and strength, and love your neighbor as yourself. The scribe agrees, and Jesus says, “You are not far from the kingdom of God.”

Then Jesus asks his own question: how can the Christ be David’s son, when David himself, in Psalm 110, says, “The Lord said to my Lord, Sit at my right hand”? The answer is that the Christ is both David’s son and David’s Lord. He warns against the scribes who devour widows’ houses and make long prayers for show. And then, in the last scene, he watches people give to the temple treasury. Many rich put in large sums. A poor widow puts in two small copper coins. Jesus calls the disciples: “This poor widow has put in more than all those who are contributing… she out of her poverty has put in everything she had, all she had to live on.” God sees the heart.

STEP 5

Connection

Zechariah 9:9 is the colt. Psalm 118:25-26 is the hosanna. Isaiah 56:7 and Jeremiah 7:11 are the temple verses. Isaiah 5:1-7 is the vineyard. Psalm 110:1 is the Lord at the right hand. Deuteronomy 6:4-5 and Leviticus 19:18 are the great commandments. Micah 7:1 and Hosea 9:10 use the fig tree as a picture of Israel. Exodus 3:6 is the God of Abraham. 2 Corinthians 8:1-5 praises generous giving in poverty.

STEP 6

Application

Ask what has crowded out prayer in your life, in your church. Clear a space.

Say the great commandment aloud: love God with your heart, soul, mind, and strength. Which part is hardest?

Give something sacrificial this week, however small, and know that God sees.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Welcome the King who comes in the name of the Lord.
- Ask him to make his church a house of prayer for all nations.
- Ask him to help you give your whole self.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 97

"And Jesus said to him, If you can! All things are possible for one who believes."

MARK 9:23

DAY 678 · WEEK 97

Mark 13:1-37

The Olivet Discourse, be watchful

Year 2 · Unit 18 · Reading · 37 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Mark 13:1-37. Jesus predicts the destruction of the temple, speaks of tribulation and false teachers, and describes the coming of the Son of Man. The call throughout is to stay awake. Read it for its pastoral purpose.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

As Jesus leaves the temple, a disciple marvels at the huge stones and buildings. Jesus says that not one stone will be left on another. Later, on the Mount of Olives, four disciples ask, "When will these things be, and what will be the sign?" His answer is the Olivet Discourse. It is one of the most debated passages in the Bible. It seems to speak both of the fall of Jerusalem in AD 70 and of the return of Christ at the end, and interpreters differ on how to divide the two.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Do you see these great buildings? There will not be left here one stone upon another that will not be thrown down" (13:2).
2. "And when you hear of wars and rumors of wars, do not be alarmed. This must take place, but the end is not yet" (13:7).
3. "And the gospel must first be proclaimed to all nations" (13:10).
4. "And you will be hated by all for my name's sake. But the one who endures to the end will be saved" (13:13).
5. "And then they will see the Son of Man coming in clouds with great power and glory" (13:26).

6. “Heaven and earth will pass away, but my words will not pass away” (13:31).
7. “But concerning that day or that hour, no one knows, not even the angels in heaven, nor the Son, but only the Father” (13:32).
8. “And what I say to you I say to all: Stay awake” (13:37).

STEP 4

Interpretation

Jesus tells the disciples not to be led astray. Many will come in his name, saying “I am he.” Wars and rumors of wars, earthquakes, and famines are “the beginning of the birth pains,” not the end. The disciples will be handed over to councils and beaten in synagogues, and will stand before governors and kings for Jesus’ sake, “to bear witness before them.” The gospel must be proclaimed to all nations. When they are arrested, they are not to worry about what to say, for the Holy Spirit will speak through them. Families will be divided, and they will be hated for his name’s sake. “But the one who endures to the end will be saved.”

Then he speaks of the “abomination of desolation” standing where it ought not to be, a phrase from Daniel. When it appears, those in Judea should flee to the mountains. There will be a tribulation such as has not been since the beginning of creation. This language fits the Roman siege of Jerusalem in AD 70, when the temple was destroyed, and many see a further fulfillment in a final tribulation. He warns again about false christs and false prophets who perform signs.

After that tribulation, the sun will be darkened, the moon will not give its light, and the stars will fall. This is the language of cosmic upheaval, used in the prophets for the fall of nations and the day of the LORD. “And then they will see the Son of Man coming in clouds with great power and glory.” This echoes Daniel 7:13. He will send out the angels and gather his elect from the four winds.

Jesus then gives a lesson from the fig tree: when you see its leaves, you know that summer is near. So when you see these things, know that he is near. “Heaven and earth will pass away, but my words will not pass away.” The time of the end is hidden: not even the Son knows it, only the Father. Jesus speaks here of his human knowledge.

The conclusion is not a timetable but a command: stay awake. A man going on a journey puts his servants in charge, and commands the doorkeeper to be on watch. The master may come in the evening, at midnight, at cockcrow, or in the morning. “Lest he come suddenly and find you asleep.” It is a call to faithful readiness, not speculation. And note that in the very next chapters, the disciples fall asleep in Gethsemane.

STEP 5

Connection

Daniel 7:13-14, 9:27, 11:31, and 12:11 are the background to the abomination of desolation and the Son of Man. Isaiah 13:10 and 34:4 use the language of cosmic signs. Joel 2:10 and 2:31 describe the sun and moon darkened. Matthew 24 and 25 and Luke 21 parallel this discourse. 1 Thessalonians 5:1-11 teaches readiness for the day of the Lord. 2 Peter 3:3-13 warns of scoffers and urges holy living. Revelation 1:7 echoes the coming with the clouds.

STEP 6

Application

Ask whether you are awake or asleep, spiritually. What would it look like to be ready?

When news of wars and disasters comes, remember: “This must take place, but the end is not yet.” Do not be alarmed.

Hold the date-setters at arm’s length, as Jesus did. Focus on faithfulness in your assigned work.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask Jesus to keep you watchful.
- Thank him that his words will never pass away.
- Ask him to keep you from being deceived.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 97

“And Jesus said to him, If you can! All things are possible for one who believes.”

MARK 9:23

DAY 679 · WEEK 97

Sabbath Rest

No new reading today. Rest, remember, and look back over the week.

Year 2 · Unit 18 · Sabbath

THE READING

Today's reading

No new reading today. Read Mark 9:23 slowly, several times, and say it from memory. Read the meditation and the week in review, and choose one of the three questions to write about, pray over, or share with someone.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

MEMORY

Memory Verse for the Week

"And Jesus said to him, If you can! All things are possible for one who believes."

MARK 9:23

REST

Meditation

Jesus says this to a father whose son is tormented. The father had said, "If you can do anything, have compassion on us and help us." Jesus takes his word and turns it back.

"If you can!" Jesus is almost surprised at the doubt in the question. It is not a question of whether Jesus can. The question is whether the father will trust. The "if" belongs not to Jesus' power but to the father's faith.

"All things are possible." This is not a blank check to get whatever we want. It is a statement about the power of God available to those who trust him. All things that fit the will of God are possible, because he is God. The one who stills the storm and raises the dead is able.

"For one who believes." The power is not in our believing but in the one we believe. Faith is the open hand that receives what God gives. Even a small and trembling faith can reach out to a great Savior.

Notice what the father does next. He says, “I believe; help my unbelief!” He does not pretend to a perfect faith. He brings his mixture of faith and doubt to Jesus. And Jesus heals his son.

When you feel your faith is too small, say this verse and then pray the father’s prayer. The weakest faith in the strongest Savior is enough.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you read the Psalm 89 vow to sing of the steadfast love of the LORD and his covenant with David. In Mark 7 and 8 you saw Jesus teach that it is the heart that defiles, heal a Gentile woman’s daughter, and ask the turning-point question, “Who do you say that I am?” Peter’s answer, “You are the Christ,” was followed by Jesus’ first teaching that the Christ must suffer. You went up the mountain and heard the Father say, “Listen to him.” You heard a father cry, “I believe; help my unbelief!” In Mark 10 you read the key verse: the Son of Man came to serve and give his life as a ransom for many. You met Bartimaeus, then watched the King enter Jerusalem, cleanse the temple, and silence every question. Finally, in the Olivet Discourse, he told you to stay awake.

REFLECT

Questions for Reflection

Jesus said he came “to give his life as a ransom for many.” What does it mean that the price of your freedom was his life?

Peter confessed that Jesus is the Christ, and then resisted the idea of a suffering Messiah. Where do you want a Jesus without a cross?

The father prayed, “I believe; help my unbelief!” What belief and what unbelief do you bring to Jesus today?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank Jesus for giving his life as a ransom for many.

Say, “I believe; help my unbelief.”

Ask him to keep you awake to him.

DAY 680 · WEEK 98

Psalm 118:19-29

The stone the builders rejected

Year 2 · Unit 18 · Psalm · 11 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 118:19-29. This is the climax of the Hallel, the psalms sung at Passover. Jesus quoted verses 22 and 23 about himself in Mark 12, and the crowds shouted verse 26 on Palm Sunday. Read it as the song of the King entering the gate.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 118 is a song of thanksgiving for victory, probably sung in a procession to the temple. The singer has been surrounded by enemies and has been saved by the LORD. Now he comes to the gates of the temple to give thanks. The last stanza, our reading, is full of lines that the New Testament applies to Jesus: the gate, the rejected stone, the day the LORD has made, and the blessed one who comes in the LORD's name.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Open to me the gates of righteousness, that I may enter through them and give thanks to the LORD" (v. 19).
2. "I thank you that you have answered me and have become my salvation" (v. 21).
3. "The stone that the builders rejected has become the cornerstone" (v. 22).
4. "This is the LORD's doing; it is marvelous in our eyes" (v. 23).
5. "This is the day that the LORD has made; let us rejoice and be glad in it" (v. 24).
6. "Save us, we pray, O LORD! O LORD, we pray, give us success!" (v. 25).
7. "Blessed is he who comes in the name of the LORD! We bless you from the house of the LORD" (v. 26).

8 “Oh give thanks to the LORD, for he is good; for his steadfast love endures forever!” (v. 29).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The singer approaches the gates of the temple and asks them to open. “This is the gate of the LORD; the righteous shall enter through it.” Only the righteous may enter the presence of God, and the question of who is righteous is raised. The answer will come in Christ. He is the righteous one who enters, and through him we enter.

The singer thanks God for answering and becoming his salvation. The word for salvation is yeshuah, the root of the name Jesus. Then comes the famous line: “The stone that the builders rejected has become the cornerstone.” The builders, perhaps the nations or the leaders, threw away a stone as unfit, and it was exactly the stone that held the building together. Israel, small and despised, was chosen by God. David, the youngest son, was passed over and made king. Above all, Jesus was rejected by the leaders of his people and made the cornerstone of the new temple, the church. He applied this verse to himself in the parable of the tenants (Mark 12:10-11), and Peter applied it in Acts 4:11. “This is the LORD’s doing; it is marvelous in our eyes.” The resurrection and exaltation of the rejected Christ is God’s doing.

“This is the day that the LORD has made; let us rejoice and be glad in it.” Christians have long sung this verse on Easter, the day the LORD made in a special way.

“Save us, we pray, O LORD!” In Hebrew, this is hoshia na, which became “Hosanna.” When the crowd shouted “Hosanna! Blessed is he who comes in the name of the Lord!” on the road to Jerusalem, they were quoting this psalm and treating Jesus as the long-awaited one. Verse 26 declares a blessing on the one who comes, and also on the pilgrims. The psalm calls for a festal procession with branches up to the horns of the altar, the same image as the palms on the road.

The psalm closes where it began: “Oh give thanks to the LORD, for he is good; for his steadfast love endures forever!” Jesus and his disciples most likely sang this psalm at the end of the Last Supper, shortly before he went to be rejected. The song he sang about the rejected stone was about himself.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 28:16 speaks of the tested cornerstone laid in Zion. Matthew 21:42, Mark 12:10-11, and Luke 20:17 record Jesus quoting verse 22. Acts 4:11, Ephesians 2:20-22, and 1 Peter 2:4-8 apply the stone to Christ. Matthew 21:9 and John 12:13 have the crowd quoting verse 26. Matthew

26:30 says they sang a hymn after the Supper. Romans 9:33 and 10:11 speak of the stone and those who believe in him. Revelation 21:22 says the Lamb is the temple.

STEP 6

Application

Pray “This is the day the LORD has made” as you start tomorrow. Choose to rejoice.

Think of a time when something rejected became a blessing in your life. Thank God for it.

Say “Hosanna” today, “Save us, we pray.” Name what needs saving.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Ask God to open the gates of righteousness for you.
- Thank Jesus, the stone the builders rejected.
- Thank him that this is the day the LORD has made.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 98

“For even the Son of Man came not to be served but to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for many.”

MARK 10:45

DAY 681 · WEEK 98

Psalm 69:1-21

Reproach has broken my heart, the suffering servant

Year 2 · Unit 18 · Psalm · 21 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Psalm 69:1-21. A suffering man drowns in trouble, hated without cause, and mocked in his thirst. Notice the lines the New Testament applies to Jesus. Read it with the cross ahead of you.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Psalm 69 is a psalm of David. It is one of the most quoted psalms in the New Testament, second only to Psalm 22 and Psalm 110 as a source of passages applied to Jesus. David pictures himself sinking in deep waters, hated by enemies, and abandoned by his family. He is a righteous sufferer. Yet he is also honest about his own sin. Jesus, who had no sin of his own, suffered all these things in a deeper way.

STEP 3

Observation

1. “Save me, O God! For the waters have come up to my neck” (v. 1).
2. “More in number than the hairs of my head are those who hate me without cause” (v. 4).
3. “O God, you know my folly; the wrongs I have done are not hidden from you” (v. 5).
4. “For it is for your sake that I have borne reproach, that dishonor has covered my face” (v. 7).
5. “For zeal for your house has consumed me, and the reproaches of those who reproach you have fallen on me” (v. 9).
6. “But as for me, my prayer is to you, O LORD. At an acceptable time, O God, in the abundance of your steadfast love answer me in your saving faithfulness” (v. 13).

7. “Reproaches have broken my heart, so that I am in despair. I looked for pity, but there was none, and for comforters, but I found none” (v. 20).

8. “They gave me poison for food, and for my thirst they gave me sour wine to drink” (v. 21).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The psalm opens with a cry of desperation: “Save me, O God! For the waters have come up to my neck.” David is sinking in deep mud with no foothold. He is weary with crying out, and his eyes grow dim with waiting for God.

His enemies are many and hate him for no reason. “I must restore what I did not steal.” He is being blamed and made to pay for what he did not do. Then, honestly, he admits: “O God, you know my folly; the wrongs I have done are not hidden from you.” He is not claiming to be sinless, but he is claiming to be innocent of the charges against him. He prays that those who hope in God will not be put to shame because of him.

The reason for his suffering is devotion to God: “For it is for your sake that I have borne reproach.” His own family treat him as a stranger. “For zeal for your house has consumed me, and the reproaches of those who reproach you have fallen on me.” The disciples remembered the second half of this verse at the cleansing of the temple (John 2:17), and Paul applied the second half to Christ in Romans 15:3. Jesus bore the reproaches directed at God.

He prays at an acceptable time, in God’s abundant steadfast love, and asks to be rescued from the mire. “Let not the flood sweep over me, or the deep swallow me up.” He asks God to answer and draw near. “You know my reproach, and my shame and my dishonor; my foes are all known to you.”

Then verse 20: “Reproaches have broken my heart, so that I am in despair. I looked for pity, but there was none, and for comforters, but I found none.” The disciples fled in Gethsemane. No one comforted him. And verse 21: “They gave me poison for food, and for my thirst they gave me sour wine to drink.” At the cross, Jesus said, “I thirst,” and was given sour wine. Matthew 27:34 and 48, and John 19:28-30, point back to this psalm.

The rest of the psalm (vv. 22 to 36) includes a harsh call for judgment on the enemies, and it ends in praise and hope. The righteous sufferer will be vindicated. We read the first half today to see the suffering that Jesus took on himself.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 22 and Isaiah 53 are other great psalms and prophecies of the righteous sufferer. John 2:17, 15:25, and 19:28-30 quote or echo this psalm. Romans 15:3 quotes verse 9 and applies it to Christ. Acts 1:20 applies verse 25 to Judas. Matthew 27:34 and 27:48 note the sour wine. Lamentations 3:54 and Jonah 2:3-5 also speak of waters over the head. Hebrews 4:15 says we do not have a high priest who cannot sympathize.

STEP 6

Application

When you feel you are sinking, pray verse 1 and verse 13 as your own.

Consider what it cost Jesus to bear reproach for God's sake. Thank him in specific words.

Ask whether your zeal for God's house is real. Bring it to the Lord in prayer.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Cry to God about what feels like drowning.
- Thank Jesus for taking the reproach of those who reproached God.
- Ask him to teach you to bear reproach for his sake.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 98

"For even the Son of Man came not to be served but to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for many."

MARK 10:45

DAY 682 · WEEK 98

Mark 14:1-52

The anointing; the Supper; Gethsemane; arrest

Year 2 · Unit 18 · Reading · 52 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Mark 14:1-52. The plot, the anointing at Bethany, the Last Supper, Peter's predicted denial, Gethsemane, and the arrest. Notice the contrast between the woman's love and Judas's betrayal, and between Jesus' prayer and the disciples' sleep.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

It is two days before Passover. The chief priests are looking for a way to arrest and kill Jesus quietly. Mark again sandwiches stories: the plot frames the anointing, and Peter's predicted denial frames the Supper and Gethsemane. Mark's account is the most raw: the disciples all flee, and a young man runs off naked. This is probably Mark himself.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Leave her alone. Why do you trouble her? She has done a beautiful thing to me" (14:6).
2. "Take; this is my body" (14:22).
3. "This is my blood of the covenant, which is poured out for many" (14:24).
4. "You will all fall away, for it is written, I will strike the shepherd, and the sheep will be scattered" (14:27).
5. "Abba, Father, all things are possible for you. Remove this cup from me. Yet not what I will, but what you will" (14:36).
6. "Watch and pray that you may not enter into temptation. The spirit indeed is willing, but the flesh is weak" (14:38).
7. "And he kissed him" (14:45).
8. "And they all left him and fled" (14:50).

STEP 4

Interpretation

In Bethany, a woman breaks an alabaster flask of costly nard and pours it on Jesus' head. Some are indignant at the waste, saying it could have been sold for three hundred denarii, nearly a year's wages. Jesus says, "Leave her alone. She has done a beautiful thing to me." She has anointed his body beforehand for burial. "Wherever the gospel is proclaimed in the whole world, what she has done will be told in memory of her." Right after this, Judas goes to the chief priests and offers to betray him.

At the Passover meal, Jesus says one of the twelve will betray him, one who is eating with him. They are sorrowful and ask, "Is it I?" He takes bread, blesses it, breaks it, and says, "Take; this is my body." He takes the cup, gives thanks, and says, "This is my blood of the covenant, which is poured out for many." This is the covenant sacrifice, like Moses sprinkling the blood at Sinai (Exodus 24:8). He will not drink again of the fruit of the vine until the day he drinks it new in the kingdom of God. They sing a hymn and go to the Mount of Olives.

On the way he says that they will all fall away, quoting Zechariah 13:7. Peter insists, "Even though they all fall away, I will not," and Jesus tells him that before the rooster crows twice, he will deny him three times. Peter says even more vehemently that he will not deny him, and they all say the same.

In Gethsemane, Jesus is "greatly distressed and troubled" and says, "My soul is very sorrowful, even to death." He falls to the ground and prays, "Abba, Father, all things are possible for you. Remove this cup from me. Yet not what I will, but what you will." Abba is the intimate word for Father. The cup is the wrath of God against sin. Jesus does not want to drink it, and yet he submits. He returns three times to find the disciples sleeping. "The spirit indeed is willing, but the flesh is weak." Then: "The hour has come. The Son of Man is betrayed into the hands of sinners."

Judas arrives with a crowd armed with swords and clubs and gives a signal: "The one I will kiss is the man." He kisses him. They seize him. One of the bystanders draws a sword and cuts off the ear of the high priest's servant. Jesus says, "Have you come out as against a robber?" and that this is to fulfill the Scriptures. Then, in Mark's sad phrase, "they all left him and fled." Jesus is utterly alone.

STEP 5

Connection

Exodus 12 and 24:8 are the Passover and the covenant blood. Jeremiah 31:31-34 promised the new covenant. Zechariah 13:7 is the shepherd struck. Psalm 41:9 predicts the betrayal by a friend. Isaiah 53:5-12 describes the servant who is pierced and who pours out his soul to

death. Psalm 42:5-6 and 116:3 are cries of a soul in distress. Romans 8:15 and Galatians 4:6 say we cry “Abba” by the Spirit. Hebrews 5:7-8 recalls his prayers with loud cries and tears.

STEP 6

Application

Pray “Abba, Father” today and let the word sink in. You are his child.

When you face a hard obedience, pray Jesus’ prayer: “Yet not what I will, but what you will.”

Remember that the Lord’s Supper proclaims his body broken and blood poured out. Receive it with thanks.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank God for the cup Jesus drank for you.
- Thank him for the blood of the covenant poured out for many.
- Pray, “Abba, Father,” and tell him what you want to give him.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 98

“For even the Son of Man came not to be served but to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for many.”

MARK 10:45

DAY 683 · WEEK 98

Mark 14:53-15:20

Trials; Peter's denial; before Pilate

Year 2 · Unit 18 · Reading · 40 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Mark 14:53-15:20. Jesus before the council, Peter's denial, Jesus before Pilate, and the mockery by the soldiers. Notice how little Jesus says, and what he does say.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Jesus is taken to the high priest's house, where the whole council assembles at night. Peter follows at a distance and sits in the courtyard. At dawn Jesus is bound and led to Pilate, the Roman governor, since the Jews have no authority to carry out a death sentence. Mark intercuts Jesus' trial and Peter's denial, so that we see the faithful Jesus and the failing Peter at the same moment.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "But he remained silent and made no answer" (14:61).
2. "I am, and you will see the Son of Man seated at the right hand of Power, and coming with the clouds of heaven" (14:62).
3. "And he broke down and wept" (14:72).
4. "Are you the King of the Jews?" And he answered him, "You have said so" (15:2).
5. "But Jesus made no further answer, so that Pilate was amazed" (15:5).
6. "For he perceived that it was out of envy that the chief priests had delivered him up" (15:10).
7. "So Pilate, wishing to satisfy the crowd, released for them Barabbas; and having scourged Jesus, he delivered him to be crucified" (15:15).

8 “And they clothed him in a purple cloak, and twisting together a crown of thorns, they put it on him” (15:17).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The council seeks testimony against Jesus to put him to death, but their witnesses disagree. Some say he threatened to destroy the temple made with hands and build another in three days. Jesus is silent, as Isaiah 53:7 foretold. Finally the high priest asks, “Are you the Christ, the Son of the Blessed?” And Jesus says, “I am.” This is the clearest public statement in Mark. Then he adds that they will see the Son of Man seated at the right hand of Power and coming with the clouds of heaven, combining Psalm 110 and Daniel 7. The high priest tears his clothes and cries blasphemy. They condemn him as deserving death, spit on him, blindfold him, and strike him.

In the courtyard, Peter warms himself by the fire. A servant girl says, “You also were with the Nazarene.” He denies it. Then again. Then bystanders say, “Certainly you are one of them, for you are a Galilean,” and he invokes a curse on himself and swears, “I do not know this man of whom you speak.” Immediately the rooster crows a second time. Peter remembers Jesus’ words, “and he broke down and wept.” The bold disciple has failed. But we know from John 21 that the story does not end here.

In the morning, Jesus is brought to Pilate, who asks, “Are you the King of the Jews?” Jesus says, “You have said so.” The chief priests make many accusations, but Jesus makes no answer, and Pilate is amazed. Pilate knows that the leaders have handed Jesus over out of envy. Each year at the feast, he releases a prisoner. The crowd is stirred up to ask for Barabbas, a rebel and murderer. “Then what shall I do with the man you call the King of the Jews?” “Crucify him!” “Why? What evil has he done?” But they shout more, “Crucify him!” So Pilate, wishing to satisfy the crowd, releases Barabbas, and after flogging Jesus, delivers him to be crucified.

The soldiers take Jesus inside and call the whole battalion. They clothe him in a purple cloak, press a crown of thorns on his head, and salute him mockingly: “Hail, King of the Jews!” They strike his head with a reed, spit on him, and kneel in mock homage. They are mocking the truth. He is the King, and one day every knee will bow. Barabbas goes free, and the innocent Son is condemned. One man was set free because Jesus took his place, as we are.

STEP 5

Connection

Isaiah 53:7 and Psalm 38:13-14 describe the silent sufferer. Daniel 7:13-14 and Psalm 110:1 are the Son of Man and the right hand. Leviticus 24:16 is the penalty for blasphemy. Isaiah 50:6 describes the servant giving his back to those who strike. Psalm 2:1-6 shows the nations raging. Philippians 2:10-11 says every knee will bow. 1 Peter 2:22-24 says he bore our sins. Romans 5:8 says Christ died for us while we were still sinners.

STEP 6

Application

Reflect on Peter's tears. Have you denied Jesus by silence or in words? Let godly sorrow lead you back to him.

Consider the silence of Jesus. Are there times to be silent under accusation?

Thank Jesus that he took the place of Barabbas, and of you.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for being condemned, mocked, and silent for you.
- Confess where you have denied him.
- Ask him for courage to confess him when it costs.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 98

"For even the Son of Man came not to be served but to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for many."

MARK 10:45

DAY 684 · WEEK 98

Mark 15:21-47

The crucifixion, the centurion's confession

Year 2 · Unit 18 · Reading · 27 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Mark 15:21-47. The march to Golgotha, the crucifixion, the cry of dereliction, the death, the tearing of the temple curtain, and the centurion's confession. This is the climax of Mark's Gospel. Read slowly.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

Jesus is led out to Golgotha, the place of the skull. Mark's account is stark. There is no mention of the forgiveness of enemies or the promise to the thief, which Luke records. Instead, Mark gives us the one cry from the cross: "My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?" Everything in the Gospel has been moving to this point, and the first human to name Jesus rightly at the cross is a Roman soldier.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "And they compelled a passerby, Simon of Cyrene, who was coming in from the country, the father of Alexander and Rufus, to carry his cross" (15:21).
2. "And the inscription of the charge against him read, The King of the Jews" (15:26).
3. "He saved others; he cannot save himself" (15:31).
4. "My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?" (15:34).
5. "And Jesus uttered a loud cry and breathed his last" (15:37).
6. "And the curtain of the temple was torn in two, from top to bottom" (15:38).
7. "Truly this man was the Son of God!" (15:39).
8. "Joseph of Arimathea, taking courage, went to Pilate and asked for the body of Jesus" (15:43).

STEP 4

Interpretation

A passerby, Simon of Cyrene, is forced to carry the cross. Mark names his sons, Alexander and Rufus, probably because they were known in the church. Rufus may be the one Paul greets in Romans 16:13. They offer Jesus wine mixed with myrrh, and he refuses it. They crucify him at the third hour, nine in the morning, and divide his garments. Above him is written, "The King of the Jews." Two robbers are crucified with him, one on his right and one on his left.

Passersby mock him: "Aha! You who would destroy the temple and rebuild it in three days, save yourself!" The chief priests and scribes say, "He saved others; he cannot save himself." They speak more truth than they know. He cannot save himself and save us. Even the robbers revile him.

At the sixth hour, noon, darkness comes over the whole land until the ninth hour. Then Jesus cries with a loud voice, "Eloi, Eloi, lema sabachthani?", "My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?" This is Psalm 22:1. In this moment, the Son bears the curse of sin and experiences the abandonment that sinners deserve. It is the deepest mystery of the cross. The Father did not abandon him because of anything he did, but because of what he bore. Some bystanders think he is calling Elijah. Someone fills a sponge with sour wine, and Jesus gives a loud cry and breathes his last.

The curtain of the temple is torn in two from top to bottom. This is the curtain between the Holy Place and the Most Holy Place. God himself tears it from the top. Access to God's presence is now open through the death of Jesus.

Then the centurion, standing in front of Jesus, sees how he died and says, "Truly this man was the Son of God!" The first to confess him as the Son of God at the cross is a Gentile soldier, one of those who had mocked him. This is the high point of Mark. The book began, "The beginning of the gospel of Jesus Christ, the Son of God." The secrecy is over. It is at the cross that we see who he really is.

Women, including Mary Magdalene, are watching from afar, and Joseph of Arimathea, a respected member of the council who was looking for the kingdom of God, boldly asks for the body and lays it in a tomb cut out of rock. The women see where he is laid.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 22 is the psalm Jesus quotes, and it ends in praise and triumph. Isaiah 53:4-6 says he bore our griefs and was pierced for our transgressions. Amos 8:9 foretold darkness at noon. Exodus 26:31-35 and Hebrews 9:8 and 10:19-20 explain the curtain. Galatians 3:13 says Christ

became a curse for us. 2 Corinthians 5:21 says God made him to be sin for us. Mark 1:1 and 1:11 echo with 15:39. Romans 16:13 mentions Rufus.

STEP 6

Application

Sit with the cry “My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?” Thank him that he was forsaken so that you never need to be.

Confess with the centurion, “Truly this man was the Son of God.” Say it aloud.

Consider the torn curtain and approach God today, boldly, because of what Jesus has done.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Thank Jesus for being forsaken so you never will be.
- Thank him for bearing the curse and the wrath.
- Say with the centurion who you believe Jesus is.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 98

“For even the Son of Man came not to be served but to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for many.”

MARK 10:45

DAY 685 · WEEK 98

Mark 16:1-20

The resurrection, "He is risen; he is not here"

Year 2 · Unit 18 · Reading · 20 verses

THE READING

Read the passage

Read Mark 16:1-20. The women find the empty tomb. Note that the earliest manuscripts end at verse 8, and verses 9 to 20 are not found in them. Many Bible translations set those verses apart. Read verses 1 to 8 as Mark's own ending, and then the longer ending as an early summary of the resurrection appearances and the commission.

Read from your own Bible. The ESV is recommended.

STEP 2

Setting the Scene

After the Sabbath, early on the first day of the week, Mary Magdalene, Mary the mother of James, and Salome bring spices to anoint Jesus' body. Their question on the way is practical: who will roll the stone away? What they find is an empty tomb and a young man in a white robe. The abrupt ending at verse 8 is deliberate: it leaves the reader to respond. The longer ending (vv. 9 to 20) was added early and summarizes appearances recorded elsewhere.

STEP 3

Observation

1. "Who will roll away the stone for us from the entrance of the tomb?" (16:3).
2. "They saw that the stone had been rolled back" (16:4).
3. "Do not be alarmed. You seek Jesus of Nazareth, who was crucified. He has risen; he is not here. See the place where they laid him" (16:6).
4. "But go, tell his disciples and Peter that he is going before you to Galilee" (16:7).
5. "And they went out and fled from the tomb, for trembling and astonishment had seized them, and they said nothing to anyone, for they were afraid" (16:8).
6. "Go into all the world and proclaim the gospel to the whole creation" (16:15).

7. “So then the Lord Jesus, after he had spoken to them, was taken up into heaven and sat down at the right hand of God” (16:19).

8. “And they went out and preached everywhere, while the Lord worked with them and confirmed the message by accompanying signs” (16:20).

STEP 4

Interpretation

The women wonder how they will move the large stone, and when they look up, they see that it has already been rolled back. Inside the tomb, a young man sits on the right side, dressed in a white robe. The women are alarmed. He says, “Do not be alarmed. You seek Jesus of Nazareth, who was crucified. He has risen; he is not here.” The One who was crucified is the One who is risen. He points to the place where they laid him, empty. Then he gives a message: “Go, tell his disciples and Peter that he is going before you to Galilee. There you will see him, just as he told you.” Notice “and Peter.” The disciple who denied him is not cast aside. He is specifically named.

Then, in the oldest manuscripts, the Gospel ends: “And they went out and fled from the tomb, for trembling and astonishment had seized them, and they said nothing to anyone, for they were afraid.” It is an abrupt ending, but it is powerful. After all that the disciples have done, the final faithful ones, the women, are also afraid. The reader is left with the announcement of the resurrection and the question: what will you do with this? We know the women did tell, because otherwise there would be no Gospel. The book ends where it began, with the good news, and invites us to carry it forward.

Verses 9 to 20, the longer ending, were probably added early. They summarize the appearance to Mary Magdalene, to two disciples on the road, and to the eleven, and give the commission: “Go into all the world and proclaim the gospel to the whole creation. Whoever believes and is baptized will be saved, but whoever does not believe will be condemned.” It ends with Jesus’ ascension and the disciples preaching everywhere with the Lord working with them. Because the status of these verses is uncertain, Christians are wise not to build doctrine or practice on them alone. In particular, the verses about handling serpents and drinking poison (vv. 17 to 18) are not taught elsewhere in the New Testament as normative. The commission itself is confirmed in Matthew 28 and Acts 1.

The resurrection is the proof of everything Jesus said. His claim to be the Christ, his death as a ransom, his promise to rise, all are vindicated. The strong Son of God who died as a servant is alive.

STEP 5

Connection

Psalm 16:10 and Isaiah 53:10-12 foreshadow the resurrection. Mark 8:31, 9:31, and 10:34 are the three predictions. Mark 14:28 promised he would go before them to Galilee. Matthew 28, Luke 24, and John 20 give the other resurrection accounts. 1 Corinthians 15:3-8 lists the appearances. Acts 1:8-11 records the commission and ascension. Romans 1:4 says he was declared to be the Son of God by his resurrection. 1 Peter 1:3 says we have a living hope through the resurrection.

STEP 6

Application

Say aloud, “He has risen; he is not here.” Let it settle.

Notice the words “and Peter.” Hear Jesus naming you in his forgiveness after your failures.

Don’t stay silent out of fear. Think of one person you can tell about the resurrection this week.

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

- Praise Jesus that he is not in the tomb.
- Thank him that the empty tomb proves his work is finished.
- Ask him to send you to tell someone.

MEMORY VERSE FOR WEEK 98

“For even the Son of Man came not to be served but to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for many.”

MARK 10:45

DAY 686 · WEEK 98

Review and Sabbath Rest

Unit 18 review, The New Covenant Inaugurated, Mark

Year 2 · Unit 18 · Review and Sabbath

MEMORY

Unit Verse

> "For even the Son of Man came not to be served but to serve, and to give his life as a ransom for many."
>
> MARK 10:45

REST

Meditation

Jesus says this to James and John, who have just asked for the best seats in his coming glory, and to the ten who are indignant. It is the key to the whole Gospel of Mark.

"For even the Son of Man." The Son of Man is the figure of Daniel 7 who receives all authority and an everlasting kingdom. If anyone deserves to be served, it is he. The word "even" marks the surprise.

"Came not to be served." He had every right to be served. He is the Lord of angels. Yet he refused to use his rights for himself. The King does not act like the kings of the Gentiles.

"But to serve." The Servant King washes feet, feeds crowds, heals the sick, touches lepers, and welcomes children. His whole life was service.

"And to give his life." Service reaches its height at the cross. His death was not a defeat but the purpose of his coming. He gave his life. No one took it from him.

"As a ransom for many." A ransom is the price paid to free a prisoner. We were captive to sin, death, and the devil. The price was his life. The "many" means a multitude beyond number, all who trust him.

When you are tempted to seek your own greatness, say this verse. The greatest of all became the servant of all, and he did it for you.

LOOK BACK

The Week in Review

This week you read Psalm 118:19-29, the song of the rejected stone that became the cornerstone, and Psalm 69:1-21, the cry of the righteous sufferer whose thirst was met with sour wine. In Mark 14 you saw the woman anoint Jesus for burial, the Supper with its words about the body and the blood of the covenant, and the prayer in Gethsemane: “Abba, Father, yet not what I will, but what you will.” You watched Judas kiss him and the disciples flee. In chapters 14 and 15 you stood by as he was tried, denied by Peter, and flogged. You stood at the cross and heard the cry, “My God, my God, why have you forsaken me?” and saw the curtain torn in two. A Roman centurion confessed him as the Son of God. Finally, you came to the empty tomb and the announcement, “He has risen.”

LOOK BACK

Unit Recap

You have read the Gospel of Mark, the fast-moving account of the servant King. It opened with the announcement that the kingdom of God is at hand, and showed Jesus acting with authority over demons, disease, nature, and death. Your doctrinal pause on the kingdom taught you to see it as already inaugurated and not yet complete. Along the way Jesus forgave sins, ate with sinners, taught in parables, and called his disciples to follow him. Again and again he silenced demons and those he healed, the so-called Messianic secret, because he would be known rightly only at the cross. At Caesarea Philippi, Peter finally confessed, “You are the Christ,” and Jesus began to teach that the Christ must suffer, be killed, and rise. The second half of the Gospel moves steadily toward Jerusalem: the Transfiguration, the passion predictions, the ransom saying of 10:45, Bartimaeus, the Entry, the temple controversies, and the Olivet Discourse. The passion narrative slows to a crawl: the anointing, the Supper, Gethsemane, the arrest, Peter’s denial, the silent King before Pilate, the cry of dereliction, and the torn curtain. A Roman centurion gave the Gospel’s climactic confession, “Truly this man was the Son of God!” And the Gospel ends at an empty tomb, with the message, “He has risen; he is not here.” Your Psalms carried the story: Psalm 107 on the stilling of the storm, Psalm 89 on David’s covenant, Psalm 118 on the rejected stone, and Psalm 69 on the righteous sufferer.

REFLECT

Review Questions

What is the “Messianic secret” in Mark?

Look at 1:25, 1:34, 1:44, 3:12, 5:43, 7:36, 8:30, and 9:9. Why do you think Jesus often commands silence? Consider how the cross changes what it means to call him the Christ, and write a few sentences.

Why does Mark's Gospel move so quickly?

Notice the repeated "immediately" and the short, vivid scenes. What kind of Savior does that pace portray? What would it have meant for a suffering church in Rome to read this Gospel?

How does Mark's Gospel build toward the cross as its climax?

Trace the three passion predictions (8:31, 9:31, 10:33-34), the ransom saying in 10:45, and the proportion of the Gospel given to the final week. How does the centurion's confession in 15:39 answer the question the Gospel has been asking?

What does Mark's Passion narrative add to the other Gospels?

Reread chapters 14 and 15. Notice the starkness: the desertion by all the disciples, the single cry of dereliction, and the absence of any comfort. What do these details teach about the cost of the cross and about following Jesus?

PRAY

Respond in Prayer

Talk to God in your own words. You might:

Thank God for the Gospel of Mark and for the Servant who gave his life as a ransom.

Tell him what you have seen of Jesus.

Ask him to keep the unit verse before you.